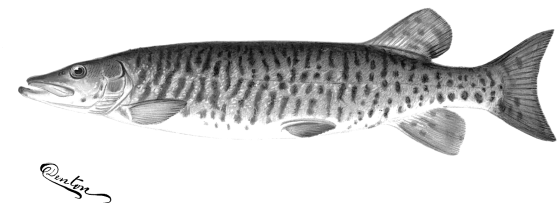


Muskellunge

Esox masquinongy

An incidental fish here — but know it on sight



The Mascalonge — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Pattern	Dark bars or spots on a <i>light</i> body — the exact reverse of a northern pike.
Cheek	Lower half of <i>both</i> the cheek and the gill cover is scaleless.
Jaw pores	Six to nine per side. A pike has five or fewer.
Tail	Lobes come to sharper points than a pike's.
Minimum	40 in, 1 per day, open water only.

Why this sheet exists
Muskellunge are not among the species the DNR lists as common in Pine Lake or North Lake. They are nonetheless regulated on both waters, at a 40 in minimum and one fish per day. If you hook a large esocid here it is almost certainly a northern pike — but you must be able to prove that to yourself before you decide what to do with it, because the two fish carry different minimum lengths and different seasons.

Musky or pike? Three checks, in order

1. Pattern	Musky: dark bars or spots on a light background. Pike: light bean-shaped spots on a dark background. The two are photographic negatives of one another.
2. Cheek & gill cover	Look at the side of the head. Musky: the lower half of <i>both</i> the cheek and the gill cover is scaleless. Pike: the whole cheek is scaled; only the lower gill cover is bare.
3. Jaw pores	Turn the head and count the pores along one side of the underside of the lower jaw. Musky: six to nine. Pike: five or fewer. This is the check that settles an argument.
Tail	A musky's tail lobes come to sharper points; a pike's are more rounded. Useful as confirmation, not as the deciding test.
Tiger musky	A pike-musky hybrid, with bold wavy bars and rounded tail lobes. It falls under the musky regulations.

If you do hook one

Decide fast	Measure it in the net, in the water. Under 40 in it goes back, full stop.
Gear	A big musky cannot be landed responsibly on panfish tackle. A large net, long pliers, jaw spreaders and bolt cutters for a buried hook are the minimum.
Release	Keep it horizontal and in the water. A musky is a long, heavy fish and its own weight in air injures it. Revive it facing into the current or move it gently forward until it swims off under its own power.
Season	Open water only, 2 May–31 December — unlike pike, there is no ice season for musky.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 40 in minimum, 1 per day, open water only, 2 May–31 December. A misidentified fish is still a violation. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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